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NEWSPAPER

27th DEC, 2018

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

52nd WEEK



EXIT OF US FORCES FROM SYRIA ... THE REAL REASONS

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... International Relations



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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS

... DISCUSSION

27th DECEMBER, 2018

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Controversial exit

Donald Trump's decision to pull U.S. troops out of Syria has rattled his team and his allies

President Donald Trump's decision to pull U.S. troops out of Syria has predictably upset both the Washington establishment and America's global allies. Within a day of the announcement, Secretary of Defense James Mattis quit, while allies say the move would affect the battle against the Islamic State in Syria. Mr. Trump, however, appears unfazed. Bringing soldiers back to the U.S. was a campaign promise. Earlier this year he had wanted to exit Syria, but delayed the decision amid resistance within his cabinet. Now he claims that the physical infrastructure of the IS caliphate is destroyed and the U.S. can leave the war against the remnants of the jihadist group to the Syrian government and its main backers, Russia and Iran. On the face of it, there is a strategic argument in Mr. Trump's decision. The caliphate is actually destroyed - the IS has lost 99% of the territory it once controlled and is now confined to narrow pockets on the Iraq-Syria border. The U.S. would also not like to get stuck in Syria forever. It is basically Russia's war. The U.S. is already stretched in Afghanistan (for 17 years) and Iraq (over 15 years) without a way out. After these interventions, Presidents have been wary of deploying "boots on the ground" in West Asia. Barack Obama had pulled back most U.S. troops from Iraq and Afghanistan. Mr. Trump wants to get out of the Syrian theatre. But the ground reality is too complex and requires Mr. Trump to be more patient and strategic in his policymaking.

The U.S. has only 2,000 troops in Syria. They were not directly involved in the ground battle, and were supporting the Syrian Democratic Forces, a rebel group led by Kurdish rebels who were in the forefront of the fight against the IS. The U.S. support for the Kurdish rebels has irked Turkey, which sees them as an extension of the Kurdistan Workers Party, the rebels on the Turkish side who have been fighting Turkish troops for decades. Turkey considers the military consolidation of Kurds as a strategic threat. In the past, Turkey had attacked Kurds in some pockets on the Syrian side, but was prevented from launching a full-throttle attack because of the U.S. presence. When Mr. Trump pulls out American troops, he would in effect be leaving the Syrian Kurds at the mercy of Turkish troops. A second risk factor will emerge if Turkey launches an attack on the Kurdish militants, which President Recep Tayyip Erdogan has vowed to do. The Kurds will then have to re-channel their resources to fight Turkish soldiers. This will weaken the ground resistance against the remaining IS militants on the southern side of the border. Mr. Trump would have done better to wait before deciding to pull out of Syria. He could have considered waiting for the conflict to de-escalate even further; also, he could have gained assurances from Turkey that it would refrain from attacking Kurdish troops. The cost of being so abrupt is that it leaves a dangerous vacuum in northeastern Syria.

Abandoned on the battlefield

The U.S. has a moral obligation to keep the Syrian Kurds safe, instead of giving Turkey a free run



STANLEY JOFFE

U.S. President Donald Trump's recent decision to pull American troops out of Syria is a body blow to the Syrian Kurds, the staunch heroes of the war against the Islamic State (IS). The U.S. began bombing the IS in September 2014 after the jihadist group announced a new Caliphate with territories spread across the Iraq-Syria border. But the bombing campaign remained largely ineffective till the U.S. found a partner on the ground to take on IS positions.

The decline of the IS actually began in Kobani, a largely Kurdish populated Syrian town on the Turkish border, in January 2014. At that time, the group was fast expanding from eastern Syria, where it established its de facto capital in Raqqa, to the border towns in the northeast. The Turkish-Syrian border remained porous, allowing the IS to transport militants in and out of Syria freely. It was the height of Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, the self-declared Caliph's bloodbath campaign, it had seized the city of Kobani. After a six-month-long

battle, the People's Protection Units (YPG), the militia of the Syrian Kurds, recaptured the beleaguered city and routed the IS. The U.S. provided air cover. It was after the battle for Kobani that then U.S. President Barack Obama realised the real strategic potential of the Kurdish rebels.

The Kobani experience was repeated in nearby towns. The YPG freed Tal Afar in July and moved to oust the IS from the Syria-Turkish border region. After these initial victories, the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), a coalition of Kurdish, Arab and American militia and led by the YPG, was formed in 2015 with the blessing of the U.S. It has since become the official defence force of the Syrian Kurds (commonly known as Rojava). The U.S. doesn't have a major troop presence in the region. Since Mr. Obama sent some 80 commandos to advise the Kurds in 2015, the number of American troops has grown to at least 2,000. But in the territories out of the grasp of the IS that are part of the Rojava, the U.S. has built massive military infrastructure - it has at least a dozen military bases, including four airfields.

Success story

This American-Kurdish partnership has been a success story. Within three years of its formation, the SDF has defeated the IS in



Most of the territories the group held. After capturing the Qamishli border area, the SDF moved to Arab-populated towns in the east such as Raqqa and Deir ez-Zor and freed them one after the other.

The IS, which once claimed territories as big as the United Kingdom, has now been confined to some narrow pockets on the Iraq-Syria border. But the U.S.'s support for the Kurds and their military victories has stirred another country in the region - Turkey. A NATO member and an American ally, the YPG (the main component of the SDF) has close ties with the Kurdistan Workers Party (PKK), the Kurdish militant group on the Turkish side which is seen as a terrorist organisation by both Ankara and Washington. Abdullah Ocalan, one of the founding leaders of the PKK, who has been imprisoned in Turkey since 1999, is revered in Rojava as well. In Turkey, the military mobilisation of the Rojava would embolden the

PKK. Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan (left, in picture) has at no time agreed that the U.S. has been backing the Kurdish rebels, who he often refers to as terrorists.

Turkey's attack on Afrin, a predominantly Kurdish town on the Syrian side, in January this year was born out of this security concern. Mr. Erdogan wants to create a buffer between the Turkish border and the Rojava. The plan is to capture the border region from Kurdish militants and hand it over to pro-Turkey rebel groups - there are Turkish and Arab rebels in Syria who got rid from Turkey. And if Turkey occupies parts of Syria on the border - Turkish-backed militants operate in Idlib, a rebel-held territory - it will also give Turkey a seat on the high table to find a solution to the Syrian crisis. But a major impediment to execute this plan has been the continuing U.S. presence in Rojava. The Afrin attack was limited in scale. Since then, Mr. Erdogan has on several occasions made empty threats to send troops to other areas, including Manbij, where U.S. troops are present. With the U.S. pulling out of Syria, it's a green light to Mr. Erdogan to make his move freely.

Support and betrayal

The U.S. has a history of supporting and betraying the Kurds. After the First World War, U.S. President

Woodrow Wilson backed the idea of autonomy for non-Turkish minorities of the Ottoman Empire. But the Allied Powers, never pushed for it. When the post-Ottoman boundaries were redrawn, the Kurds were split among four countries - Turkey, Syria, Iraq and Iran. In all these countries, they have been a persecuted minority. The example of the Iraqi Kurds is telling.

Unfortunately, the Syrian Kurds face the same fate. Syrian Kurdistan is not a constitutionally recognised autonomous entity like Iraq Kurdistan. They are surrounded by enemies, the remnants of the IS, a reformed, neo-Nazi Turkish military and the blood-soaked Syrian regime. In theory, the U.S. pulling out of an illegal war is fine - the American intervention has neither congressional approval nor the UN Security Council's nod. But in practice, since the U.S. intervention, has already started shaping the reality on the ground, the pull-out should have been an orderly one. The U.S. has the moral obligation to ensure the safety of the Syrian Kurds. It could have used the pull-out as a bargaining chip to get concessions from Ankara and Damascus. Instead, Mr. Trump's abrupt decision leaves the Kurds reeling in the aftermath.

—stanley.joffe@hindustan.com

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GS II ... International Relations

Effect of policies and politics of developed and developing countries on India's interests, Indian diaspora.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

27th December, 2018



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THE HINDU
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2 Controversial exit

Donald Trump's decision to pull U.S. troops out of Syria has rattled his team and his allies. President Donald Trump's decision to pull U.S. troops out of Syria has predictably upset both the Washington establishment and America's global allies. Within a day of the announcement, Secretary of Defense James Mattis quit, while allies say the move would affect the battle against the Islamic State in Syria. Mr. Trump, however, appears unfazed. Bringing soldiers back to the U.S. was a campaign promise. Earlier this year he had wanted to exit Syria, but delayed the decision amid resistance within his cabinet. Now he claims that the physical infrastructure of the IS caliphate is destroyed and the U.S. can leave the war against the remnants of the jihadist group to the Syrian government and its main backers, Russia and Iran. On the face of it, there is a strategic argument in Mr. Trump's decision. The caliphate is actually destroyed — the IS has lost 95% of the territory it once controlled and is now confined to narrow pockets on the Iraqi-Syrian border. The U.S. would also not like to get stuck in Syria forever. It is basically Russia's war. The U.S. is already stranded in Afghanistan (for 17 years) and Iraq (over 15 years) without a way out. After these interventions, Presidents have been wary of deploying "boots on the ground" in West Asia. Barack Obama had pulled back most U.S. troops from Iraq and Afghanistan. Mr. Trump wants to get out of the Syrian theatre. But the ground reality is too complex and requires Mr. Trump to be more patient and strategic in his policymaking.

2 Controversial exit

The U.S. has only 2,000 troops in Syria. They were not directly involved in the ground battle, and were supporting the Syrian Democratic Forces, a rebel group led by Kurdish rebels who were in the forefront of the fight against the IS. The U.S. support for the Kurdish rebels has irked Turkey, which sees them as an extension of the Kurdistan Workers Party, the rebels on the Turkish side who have been fighting Turkish troops for decades. Turkey considers the military consolidation of Kurds as a strategic threat. In the past, Turkey had attacked Kurds in some pockets on the Syrian side, but was prevented from launching a full-throttle attack because of the U.S. presence. When Mr. Trump pulls out American troops, he would in effect be leaving the Syrian Kurds at the mercy of Turkish troops. A second risk factor will emerge if Turkey launches an attack on the Kurdish militants, which President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan has vowed to do. The Kurds will then have to re-channel their resources to fight Turkish soldiers. This will weaken the ground resistance against the remaining IS militants on the southern side of the border. Mr. Trump would have done better to wait before deciding to pull out of Syria. He could have considered waiting for the conflict to de-escalate even further; also, he could have gained assurances from Turkey that it would refrain from attacking Kurdish troops. The cost of being so abrupt is that it leaves a dangerous vacuum in northeastern Syria.

2 Abandoned on the battlefield

The U.S. has a moral obligation to keep the Syrian Kurds safe, instead of giving Turkey a free run.

U.S. President Donald Trump's recent decision to pull American troops out of Syria is a body blow to the Syrian Kurds, the unsung heroes of the war against the Islamic State (IS). The U.S. began bombing the IS in September 2014 after the jihadist group announced a new Caliphate with territories spread across the Iraqi-Syrian border. But the bombing campaign remained largely ineffective till the U.S. found a partner on the ground to take on IS positions.

The decline of the IS actually began in Kobane, a largely Kurdish-populated Syrian town on the Turkish border, in January 2015. At that time, the group was fast-expanding from eastern Syria, where it established its de facto capital in Raqqa, to the border towns in the northeast. The Turkish-Syrian border remained porous, allowing the IS to transport militants in and out of Syria freely. It was the height of Abu Bakr al-Baghdadi, the self-declared Caliph's bloodbath campaign. It laid siege to the city of Kobane. After a six-month-long battle, the People's Protection Units (YPG), the militia of the Syrian Kurdistan, recaptured the battered city and ousted the IS. The U.S. provided air cover. It was after the battle for Kobane that then U.S. President Barack Obama realised the real strategic potential of the Kurdish rebels.

The Kobane experience was repeated in nearby towns. The YPG freed Tal Abyad in July and moved to oust the IS from the Syria-Turkish border region. After these initial victories, the Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF), a coalition of Kurdish, Arab and Assyrian militias and led by the YPG, was formed in 2015 with the blessings of the U.S. It has since become the official defence force of the Syrian Kurdistan (commonly known as Rojava). The U.S. doesn't have a major troops presence in the region. Since Mr. Obama sent some 50 commandos to advise the Kurds in 2015, the number of American troops has grown to at least 2,000. But in the territories east of the Euphrates that are part of the Rojava, the U.S. has built massive military infrastructure — it has at least a dozen military bases, including four airfields.

2 Abandoned on the battlefield

Success story

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Turkey's attack on Afrin, a predominantly Kurdish town on the Syrian side, in January this year was born out of this security concern. Mr. Erdoğan wants to create a buffer between the Turkish border and the Rojava. The plan is to capture the border region from Kurdish militants and hand it over to pro-Turkey rebel groups — there are Turkmen and Arab rebels in Syria who get aid from Turkey. And if Turkey occupies parts of Syria on the border — Turkish-backed militants operate in Idlib, a rebel-held territory — it will also give Turkey a seat on the high table to find a solution to the Syria crisis. But a major impediment to execute this plan has been the continuing U.S. presence in Rojava. The Afrin attack was limited in scale.

2 Abandoned on the battlefield

Since then, Mr. Erdoğan has on several occasions made empty threats to send troops to other areas, including Manbij, where U.S. troops are present. With the U.S. pulling out of Syria, it's a green light to Mr. Erdoğan to make his moves freely.

Support and betrayal

The U.S. has a history of supporting and betraying the Kurds. After the First World War, U.S. President Woodrow Wilson backed the idea of autonomy for non-Turkish minorities of the Ottoman Empire. But the Allied Powers never pushed for it. When the post-Ottoman boundaries were redrawn, the Kurds were split among four countries — Turkey, Syria, Iraq and Iran. In all these countries, they have been a persecuted minority. The example of the Iraqi Kurds is telling.

Unfortunately, the Syrian Kurds face the same fate. Syrian Kurdistan is not a constitutionally recognised autonomous entity like Iraqi Kurdistan. They are surrounded by enemies, the remnants of the IS, a vengeful, insecure Turkish military and the blood-soaked Syrian regime. In theory, the U.S. pulling out of an illegal war is fine — the American intervention has neither congressional approval nor the UN Security Council's nod. But in practice, since the U.S. intervention has already started shaping the reality on the ground, the pull-out should have been an orderly one. The U.S. has the moral obligation to ensure the safety of the Syrian Kurds. It could have used the pull-out as a bargaining chip to get concessions both from Ankara and Damascus. Instead, Mr. Trump's abrupt decision leaves the Kurds twisting in the whirlwind.



RUSSIA

Black Sea

Istanbul

Ankara

TURKEY

Black Sea

Georgia

Armenia

Azerbaijan

Caspian Sea

SYRIA

IRAQ

Damascus

Lebanon

Israel

Jordan

Greece

Albania

Macedonia (FYROM)

Bulgaria

Serbia

Bosnia and Herzegovina

Croatia

Adriatic Sea

Aegean Sea

Ionian Sea

Mediterranean Sea

Cyprus

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DEMAND FOR KURDISTAN



- US began bombing IS in September, 2014.
- Success could be achieved only after US found a partner i.e. People's Protection Units (YPG), the militia of the Syrian Kurdistan.
- The decline began in Kobane, largely Kurdish populated Syrian town on the Turkish border.
- Then, US President realised the real potential of Kurdish rebels.
- The Kobane experience was repeated in nearby towns.
- After the initial victories, predominantly by YPG, the Syrian Democratic Forces, a coalition of Kurdish, Arab and Assyrian militias and led by the YPG was formed in 2015.



WITHDRAWAL OF US TROOPS FROM SYRIA



1 US has started bringing home troops from Syria, it said the militant Islamic State's territorial caliphate has been defeated.

2 Mr. Trump declared victory against the Group.

3 US has about 2,000 troops in Syria, many of them, Special Operations Forces, working closely with an alliance of Kurdish and Arab Militias known as the Syrian Democratic Force or SDF.

4 The partnership with SDF led to the defeat of IS in Syria, but, it outraged Turkey, which views Kurdish YPG Forces in the alliance as an extension of militant group fighting inside Turkey.

USA DECISION AND REASONS AS STATED BY USA!



DONALD TRUMP
President, USA



- 1 It was his election promise. Physical infrastructure of IS Caliphate is destroyed.
- 2 US can leave the war against the Jihadist Group to the Syrian Government and its backers, Russia and Iran.
- 3 The IS lost about 95% of the territory, it once controlled.
- 4 US would not like to stuck in Syria forever. US is already stranded in Afghanistan for 17 years and Iraq for over 15 years without a way-out.

WHAT ARE THE REAL REASONS?



- 1** US has only 2,000 troops in Syria, they were not directly involved in the ground battle.
- 2** They were supporting the Syrian Democratic Forces, a rebel group led by Kurdish rebels.
- 3** US support for the Kurdish rebels, antagonized Turkey. It sees them as an extension of Kurdistan Workers Party in Turkey. They are fighting Turkish troops for decades.

WHAT ARE THE REAL REASONS?



- 4 Turkey feels military consolidation of Kurds as a strategic threat.
- 5 Turkey attacked Kurds in some pockets on the Syrian side, but was prevented from launching full-fledged attack because of US presence.
- 6 When US pulls out its troops, then Syrian Kurds may be at the mercy of Turkish troops, then, it will weaken ground resistance against remaining IS militants on the southern side of the Border.

THE DECISION IS BECAUSE OF TURKEY!



- 1 Turkey wants to create a buffer from the Turkish Border. The plan is to capture the border region from Kurdish militants and hand it over to pro-Turkey rebel groups.
- 2 These are Turkmen and Arab rebels in Syria, who get aid from Turkey.
- 3 When U.S. pulls out of Syria, it gives freedom to Mr. Erdogan to make his moves freely.

KURDISTAN NEVER BECAME A REALITY!



- 1 After the First World War, U.S. President Woodrow Wilson backed the idea of autonomy for non-Turkish minorities of the Ottoman Empire. But the Allied Powers never pushed for it.
- 2 When the boundaries were drawn after the Ottoman Empire, Kurds were split among four countries — Turkey, Syria, Iraq and Iran.
- 3 In all these countries, they have been a persecuted minority.

KURDISTAN NEVER BECAME A REALITY!



4 In the 1970s, the U.S. backed the Iraqi Kurds in rebelling against pro-Soviet Baathists.

5 But they abandoned them after Iran, the then American ally, signed the Algiers Accord to settle border dispute with Iraq in 1975.

6 In the next 15 years, the Kurds in northern Iraq have seen the worst form of repression by Baghdad, including a chemical attack in 1988.

FINALLY, WHAT ABOUT SYRIAN KURDS?



- 1 Syrian Kurdistan is not a constitutionally recognized autonomous entity, like Iraqi Kurdistan
- 2 They are surrounded by enemies, like IS, Turkish military etc.
- 3 U.S. has the moral obligation to ensure the safety of the Syrian Kurds.
- 4 It could have used the pull-out as a bargaining chip to get concessions from both Ankara and Damascus.

Now Syrian Kurds will be put in most difficult situation.

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